

and a 6-mic array for noise cancellation on calls. And the ANC complimented by the excellent Transparency mode, makes it a very well-rounded package. Kudos to realme for their feature selection and implementation!

PERFORMANCE

Coming to the the performance of the realme Buds Air 5 Pro, the brand with these earbuds has included a pair of co-axial drivers in these earbuds. What this means is that instead of only one driver being present in the buds, there are two drivers packed in to ensure that they are handling the reproduction of different frequencies. Now, when such a thing is implemented in earbuds, the problem of auditory masking comes in very frequently. What it means is that, due to a disparity in the tuning of the two drivers producing different frequencies, one range of frequencies, for example, the lows, might overpower or adversely affect the other, for example, highs.

Before moving on to the performance analysis, a word about the driver selection by realme in the Buds Air 5 Pro. The earbuds have an 11 + 6 mm driver configuration, with the 11 mm driver being the one handling the low frequencies, which is the bass, and the 6 mm driver handling the mids and the highs.

Now, when listening to the earbuds, I could definitely feel the presence of the two-driver setup, both in a good and a bad way. And when I ran it through our test setup, I was satisfied to know what I had been thinking about these buds. As you can see, there is a massive boost in the bass frequencies, meaning that the earbuds have a lot of thump in their sound. Now, while bass lovers will celebrate this fact, anyone who is a fan of listening to music that is heavy on the vocals will know what this means and would feel like. As I had prefaced, there is some auditory masking happening around the low mids and the high bass frequencies.

While it is not as bad as some of the other examples I have come across in my training period, for me, it was enough to bring down some of the scores of the earbuds in our scoring

sheet. In tracks like Uptown Funk, where there is a very heavy bass line present, the vocals of the backing artists go for a toss. And, the same in movies. If you are watching a sequence with an ensemble of actors with a bassy voice, then you will be lost, hunting for some of the dialogues here and there.

If you are a fan of music genres like pop, hip-hop, or Bollywood, basically any form of music that has a LOT of bass-heavy instruments like drums and bass guitars, these earbuds will put a smile on your face. However, purists, be ready to take the realme Link app for a spin to ensure that the audio is as close to neutral as possible.

For whatever reason, you are not willing to take the extra effort of tuning the audio to your liking, then I would recommend you look at the Oppo Enco Air 3 Pro TWS earbuds. They come at the same price, have a great fit, feature set, and sound signature that came very close to our baseline Pink Noise readings, but with a boost in the highs. So keep that in mind!

Coming to the ANC, it did its job well. In heavy traffic, when on the sidewalk, I could hear the occasional high-pitched horn and vehicle sounds creeping in, but for the most part, the earphones did the job well. In indoor environments, like my office, when I had these earphones on, I could barely hear my co-workers who are far away from me, and the sound of the AC, which sits right above my head was also muted for the most part. The adaptive ANC was a hit and a miss. To describe its working, I would like to use a fabled internet quote - Sometimes maybe good, sometimes maybe s...

The microphone on these earbuds, thanks to the 6-Mic array that is there at work eliminates any unnecessary noise from seeping into your calls. The audio was slightly coloured to make it bass-heavy. But that was the case with me. Your mileage may vary depending on how you sound, what environment you are in, and what the computational algorithm thinks your voice should sound like. All in all, excellent work realme!

BATTERY LIFE

realme claims that the Buds Air 5 Pro sport a 40-hour battery life in total, with the buds lasting 11 hours. When I put these earbuds to test, with ANC on and volume set to 50 per cent, the buds lasted about 8 hours and 48 minutes before running out of charge. Now, assuming that you turn ANC off, you can definitely clock in numbers close to the ones claimed by realme. Again, well done. If you are out of charge, then realme claims that you would in no time be able to juice these up. As per the brand's claims, you can get up to 7 hours of music playback with just 10 minutes of charge. That is awesome!

VERDICT

In terms of effort, I would give realme a solid A+. These earbuds surely stand out in the market filled with offerings like the Jabra Elite 4 and the Nothing Ear (2), both of which make compelling cases for themselves.

The build, features, and battery life of the realme Buds Air 5 Pro, coupled with their dual driver design, makes them a great recommendation. If you are not a fan of their bass-forward sound signature, then you can change that in the app. But, if that is something that you do not want to do, then I would say go for the Oppo Enco Air 3 Pro. And, if you want a pair of TWS earbuds with better performance, no ANC, but excellent fit and battery life, then I would say, spend some extra money and go for the Sony WF-C500 earbuds.

—Satvik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Color: Astral Black, Sunrise Beige | Audible unit: 11mm+6mm dual drivers | Frequency response range: 20Hz to 40KHz | Number of microphones: 3 PCS per earbud | Impedance: 11mm driver: 32Ω, 6mm driver: 9Ω | Bluetooth codec: AAC, SBC, and LDAC | Bluetooth version: 5.3 | Charging case size: 68.3mm × 48.4mm × 24.5mm | Earbud size: 30.2mm × 20.5mm × 24.7mm | Waterproof level: IPX5 (Buds only)

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